

Shiitake-apple risotto

This risotto is tart, creamy, and **luxurious**. I have found that a sharp apple is always a pleasant surprise in a hot savory dish. This recipe serves two as a main course, four as a first course or side dish. Have everything prepped and ready to go on the counter before you begin cooking.

4 cups vegetable stock [1L]

1 small onion, finely chopped

1½ tablespoons olive oil or butter

½ pound fresh shiitake mushrooms,
stemmed, caps thinly sliced [250g]

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 small Granny Smith apple, cored and cut
into ½-inch [1-cm] dice

1 cup Arborio or other risotto rice [200g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons freshly grated Parmesan
cheese

2 teaspoons fresh thyme, minced

1. **Bring** the vegetable stock to a simmer on the burner closest to your risotto pan. You will need a solid wooden spoon and a ½-cup [125-ml] ladle.
2. In heavy-bottomed saucepan, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium-low heat until softened and translucent, 3 to 5 minutes. While it's not the end of the world if you do so, try to avoid browning the onion. Add the mushrooms and garlic and cook until the mushrooms are soft, about 5 minutes.
3. Add the apple and stir once or twice. **Add** the rice and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 to 2 minutes, until the grains begin to turn opaque. Raise the heat to medium-high and ladle in 1 cup [250ml] simmering stock. The liquid should quickly boil and then simmer until you are finished. Find the right level on your stovetop so that the risotto is not at a rolling boil but at a constant light simmer.
4. Continue to stir without stopping, getting all sides and the bottom of the pan, so the rice does not stick or burn. You are now officially on your way. Keep stirring until the liquid is absorbed and evaporated. **Ladle** in ½ cup [125ml] more hot liquid and repeat the process until the pan is again void of much stock.

5. After 15 minutes or so of cooking, **season** with salt and pepper and get a quick taste. Is your rice too crunchy? It probably will be, but this is the time for you to make choices. Risotto should be tender but firm to the bite. You may add slightly less liquid now at each addition until you get your desired results in about 20 to 25 minutes total. I find I use from 3 to 3½ cups [750 to 875ml] total liquid, though once I used 4 cups [1L]. Be prepared to modify to the needs of the risotto.
6. When the risotto is done, remove it from the heat, **stir** in the cheese and thyme, and season again generously with salt and pepper. Serve immediately. Like a soufflé, properly made risotto waits for no one.

SERVES 2 TO 4

